that purpose both colonial powers arbitrarily declared the Tutsis as being ‘racially superior’ to the Hutus.

As we have seen, Buddhist extremists paint a similar picture of the Rohingyas. It is claimed that they owe their loyalty to a foreign power (Saudi Arabia is the usual nominated state) and it is true that the British favoured various ethnic and religious groups. In particular, the colonial civil service included many Muslims.

The unfortunate long-term consequence of European favouritism in Rwanda was that the independence movement after World War II took on an overtly ethnic aspect, as Hutus targeted the Tutsis due to their alleged support for Belgian rule. Independence consequently brought with it ongoing ethnic violence, and as many as 300,000 Tutsis had been forced to flee the country by the mid-1960s.

This exile community formed what was to become the Rwandan Patriotic Front, which commenced a limited invasion of Rwanda in the late 1980s. The advent of a multi-party government in early 1992 heralded a ceasefire. However, the political process of reconciliation was opposed by Hutu hardliners who started to make detailed plans for widespread massacres of Tutsis.[28] The actual genocide commenced in April 1994, after the president’s plane was shot down by the army.

Perhaps the best example of how critical is the creation of the background for genocide is that of the Nazi genocide against Europe’s Jews. It is the most studied of recent genocides, and offers clear examples of the importance of slow escalation of inter-group antagonism and the creation of a culture of violence as preconditions for genocide. Such a gradual development of the conditions of genocide both creates a feeling of normality towards violence across society, and also enables a gradual testing of the likely reaction of the international community.

The Nazis drew on the long-standing European narratives of anti-Semitism and the late-nineteenth-century political concept of racial purity.[29] This enabled them to identify the Jewish community as alien and a fundamental threat to their vision of a racially pure Germany. However, while they came to power determined to remove Jewish influence from Germany (and Europe) it is certainly not apparent that they started with a clear plan for mass murder. The initial racial laws were designed to ban Jews from defined professions and to ensure they were second-class citizens. The goal seemed to be to bring about the forced migration of Jews